city of Ahmedabad, on the banks of the Sabarmati River, will always be special.

India very rarely lose a Test series at home, possibly because they have such exceptionally constructive working relationships with the groundsmen at their home venues. We arrive in Kanpur to play the third and last Test and are not hugely surprised to find an underprepared wicket at the Green Park Stadium.

Graeme wins the toss again, which usually helps on the subcontinent, but we are bowled out on the first day, fading from 152 for one to be all out for 265. Still we fight hard and reduce the home side to 279 for nine towards the end of the second day. Parity on first innings will give us a chance but, on the second evening and into the third morning, Sreesanth and Sharma proceed to add 46 runs for the tenth wicket.

There is almost nothing in cricket, or maybe in life, as frustrating as a tenth-wicket partnership that, over by over, edged single by edged single, stolen run by stolen run, takes a match away from you.

So it proves in Kanpur as India somehow reaches 325. With the pitch quickly deteriorating, we subside to 121 all out in our second innings. India win, and the series ends in a 1–1 draw.

Five days later, the world of cricket is forever changed by the launch of the first Indian Premier League (IPL), a 20-over competition contested by eight franchises. Most of the world's leading cricketers are put up for auction and the team owners bid against each other, paying players extraordinary sums of money for seven weeks' work. I am signed by the Delhi Daredevils for US$300 000, an average salary in the IPL, an astronomical sum for me.

Saturday, 12 July 2008

Our team briefing at the close of play has started, and Graeme Smith is not happy. We have been outplayed in the first two days of the first Test